The ultimate policy shift, however, occurred in 2010 with the rise of Menon as NSA and Chidambaram as home minister. Instead of offering blanket opposition to the idea of reconciling with the Afghan Taliban, India developed a nuanced approach to negotiations, with the hope of influencing the terms of these talks. The 2011 India-Afghanistan Strategic Partnership Agreement (SPA) and subsequent interaction between Kabul and New Delhi were steps in that direction. The rise of the conciliators in 2010 within India's policy bureaucracy did not mean that the value of coercion (either overt or covert) was lost upon India. The criticism that Manmohan Singh and Menon often face is that they were too soft on Pakistan and Afghanistan. Narayanan, some argue, was better at playing hardball with Pakistan and the 'great game' in Afghanistan.[169] This assessment is misplaced. Conciliators such as Menon resorted to force when required without hesitation. What they did not do was make it public. India's covert war with Pakistan, or support to the NDS in its strategic endeavours, was not called off under Menon's watch. If anything, silently but surely, India had ensured that (1) Pakistan continued to remain politically marginalised in Afghanistan, (2) such marginalisation did not impede New Delhi's talks with Islamabad, and (3) India is not viewed as an obstructionist regional power. The next and final chapter of this book shows how changing international dynamics influenced change in India's Afghanistan policy towards a more conciliatory direction.